# Team Aarav - VoltRide: Fix Pune First

*Case Prompt - Inter-University Strategy Challenge 2026, Round 2. VoltRide Mobility operates 1,800 dockless electric scooters in Pune and completed 410,000 rides in the last financial year. The founders must decide whether to expand into three tier-2 cities (Nagpur, Indore and Coimbatore) within eighteen months or to deepen operations in Pune by adding battery-swapping stations and corporate subscriptions. Teams must assess market attractiveness, unit economics per scooter, regulatory risk and the funding required for each option. Your submission must recommend one option, justify it with quantitative reasoning, identify the three largest risks and propose mitigation measures for each. Answers should not exceed 1,500 words excluding this prompt. Use only the case exhibits and publicly available sources, and cite every external source you rely on. Submissions will be scored on insight, rigour, feasibility and clarity of communication.*

## 1. Situation

VoltRide is not short of demand in Pune. The fleet did 410,000 rides last year, which works out to roughly 228 rides per scooter, and the app still shows riders waiting at Hinjewadi and Kharadi during the morning peak. The problem is supply quality, not supply quantity. Exhibit 2 shows that about a fifth of the fleet is unavailable at any given hour because scooters are either flat or sitting in the depot. Expanding to three new cities would copy that broken operating model three more times.

## 2. Unit economics

We rebuilt the unit economics from Exhibit 3. A scooter costs 62,000 rupees landed, lasts about thirty months and earns 212 rupees a day at current utilisation. After charging, van logistics, repairs and insurance it contributes only 41 rupees a day, so payback takes more than four years, which is longer than the scooter survives. Any option that does not raise rides per scooter is therefore value destroying, no matter how big the new market looks on paper.

## 3. Recommendation

Our recommendation is to stay in Pune for the next eighteen months and build a dense battery-swapping network before chasing new cities. Right now each scooter spends almost forty minutes a day off the road waiting for a van to collect and recharge it, and that idle time is the biggest reason the fleet earns so little. Twenty swap stations near the busiest pickup zones would lift utilisation from 5.1 to 6.4 rides per scooter per day.

## 4. Risks and mitigation

The first risk is regulatory. Pune Municipal Corporation has already capped dockless fleets in the old city wards, and a stricter parking rule could force us to build designated parking bays at our own cost. We would reduce this exposure by co-funding thirty marked parking hubs with the corporation and sharing anonymised trip data with its traffic cell, which turns the regulator into a partner rather than an opponent.

The second risk is battery degradation. Swap stations cycle batteries harder than overnight depot charging, and if pack life falls below eight hundred cycles the station economics break down. A leasing contract with the battery supplier, priced per kilowatt-hour delivered rather than per pack, moves this risk onto the party that understands the chemistry best.

The third risk is that a well funded rival enters Pune while we are busy building stations. Honestly we think this is the smallest of the three, because a swap network is expensive to copy and riders stick with whichever app has a charged scooter closest to them. Locking in the twenty best station sites early is our main defence.

## References

VoltRide Mobility Case Exhibits 1-4, Inter-University Strategy Challenge 2026.

Wikipedia contributors. Scooter-sharing system. Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia. Accessed October 2026.